

152

# Ananias and Sapphira

*A couple who lied about a gift, and a young church that learned to fear God.*

In the first days of the Jerusalem church, believers shared what they had so that no one went without. Some sold land and brought the money to the apostles, as Barnabas did. Ananias and his wife Sapphira also sold property. But they agreed to keep back part of the price while appearing to give it all. Peter said the land and money had always been theirs to keep. Their sin was the lie. First Ananias, then Sapphira, fell down dead. It is a sobering reminder that God sees the heart, and that honesty matters more than the size of a gift.

## At a glance

|                        |                                                                 |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Names</i>           | Ananias, "the LORD is gracious"; Sapphira, probably "beautiful" |
| <i>Family</i>          | Husband and wife (Acts 5:1)                                     |
| <i>When</i>            | Early years of the Jerusalem church, c. AD 30–33                |
| <i>Key places</i>      | Jerusalem                                                       |
| <i>Key people</i>      | Peter; the apostles; Barnabas                                   |
| <i>Main passages</i>   | Acts 4:32–5:11                                                  |
| <i>Not the same as</i> | Ananias of Damascus (Acts 9:10) or the high priest (Acts 23:2)  |

*"Whiles it remained, was it not thine own? ... thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God."*

Acts 5:4, KJV

# The life of Ananias and Sapphira

*Acts gives no date. The story comes early in Acts, before Stephen's death, so it probably happened within a few years of Pentecost, c. AD 30–33.*

|                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jerusalem<br><i>Early church</i> | ● The church shares<br>The believers are "of one heart and of one soul." They hold all things in common, and those who own land or houses sell them and lay the money at the apostles' feet. <i>Acts 4:32–35</i>   |
| Jerusalem<br><i>Early church</i> | ● Barnabas gives his land<br>Josés, called Barnabas, a Levite from Cyprus, sells land and brings all the money to the apostles. His generosity sets the scene for what follows. <i>Acts 4:36–37</i>                |
| The sale                         | ● A plan to deceive<br>Ananias and Sapphira sell a possession. With his wife's full knowledge, Ananias keeps back part of the price and lays only a portion at the apostles' feet. <i>Acts 5:1–2</i>               |
| Before Peter                     | ● Ananias dies<br>Peter asks why Satan has filled his heart "to lie to the Holy Ghost." Hearing Peter's words, Ananias falls down and dies. Young men wrap his body, carry him out and bury him. <i>Acts 5:3–6</i> |
| About three hours later          | ● Sapphira dies<br>Sapphira comes in, not knowing what has happened. Peter asks whether they sold the land for so much, and she says yes. She too falls down dead at his feet. <i>Acts 5:7–10</i>                  |
| Afterward                        | ● Great fear<br>Great fear comes on the whole church and on all who hear. The apostles do many signs, and believers are added to the Lord, "multitudes both of men and women." <i>Acts 5:11–14</i>                 |

## Key activities

*Readers have long asked why the judgment was so severe. Acts does not explain it. Many see it as a warning at the church's founding, like the judgments on Nadab and Abihu and on Achan at the start of Israel's worship and conquest.*

- 1 Sold a possession.** Like others in the church, they sold property. Peter says the land and the money were theirs to use as they chose. *Acts 5:1, 4*
- 2 Kept back part of the price.** Ananias kept back part of the money, "his wife also being privy to it." *Acts 5:2*
- 3 Lied to the Holy Ghost.** Peter told Ananias, "thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God." *Acts 5:3-4*
- 4 Agreed together.** Peter asked Sapphira, "How is it that ye have agreed together to tempt the Spirit of the Lord?" *Acts 5:8-9*
- 5 Died under judgment.** Each of them fell down and died when confronted with the lie. *Acts 5:5, 10*

## Group notes

# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; the couple is not named in the Old Testament.

## Old Testament

|                        |                                                |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Echo: Joshua 7         | Achan secretly keeps back what belonged to God |
| Echo: Leviticus 10:1–2 | Nadab and Abihu judged at worship's start      |
| Echo: 1 Samuel 16:7    | "The LORD seeth not as man seeth"              |

## New Testament

|                         |                                                                             |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Acts 5:1–11             | The only account of the couple                                              |
| Acts 4:36–37            | Barnabas's honest gift just before their story                              |
| Echo: Ephesians 4:25    | Put away lying; speak truth with your neighbour                             |
| Echo: 2 Corinthians 9:7 | "God loveth a cheerful giver"                                               |
| Debated                 | Were they true believers disciplined, or never converted? Acts does not say |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* According to Peter, whose was the land and the money before and after the sale (Acts 5:4)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think lying about a gift was treated so seriously in the church's early days?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to seem more generous or spiritual than you are?
4. *Apply:* Sapphira had a moment to tell the truth (Acts 5:8). What do you need to be honest about this week?